Understanding Development (GE)

Assignment - 2

Name : Aryan Kushwaha
Roll no. : 24570 3428
Course : B.Sc. (H) Computer Science
Topic : Goal of Alternative development models in de-essentializing "development".

...u, for a moment, that an alien spaceship lands on Earth. The extraterrestrials step out, look around, and ask to speak to our manager. They want to know what humanity's primary goal is. If you ask a politician, an economist, or a guy in a tailored suit on Wall street, they will probably look the alien dead in the eye and say one magical, heavily loaded word: Development.

But what does that word actually mean?

If you look around the world today, "development" seems to have a specific, rigid definition. It means replacing forests with shopping malls. It means everyone wearing Western clothes, speaking english, working 40 to 60 hours a week, and buying a new smartphone every 2 years. Most importantly, it means a magical line on a graph called GDP must go up forever. If the line goes up, we are "developing". If the line goes down, it is a tragedy of epic proportions, even if the air is cleaner and people are sleeping better.

This rigid, one-size-fits-all definition is what accademics call the "essentialisation" of development. It treats this specific, highly destructive, Western-centric model as the absolute "essence" of progress. It assumes there is only one ladder to success, and everyone on Earth needs to climb it.

But what if the ladder is leaning against the wrong wall? What if the ladder is actually on fire?

This is where alternative development models step in. The core goal of these alternative models is not to drag humanity back to the stone age, as some critics like to claim. Instead, their goal is to de-essentialize development. In simple terms, they want to break the illusion that there is only one way to live, progress, and be happy. They want to show us that a good life does not have to look like a traffic jam in New York City.

The Original Sin: How we Essentialised Development

To understand how we de-essentialize development, we have to look at how it got essentialised in the first place.

US President Harry S. Truman gave his inaugural address. In it, he casually referred to half the world as "underdeveloped areas." With a few sentences, Truman essentially hit the "reset" button on global cultures. Thousands of years of diverse histories, agricultural systems, and social philosophies were suddenly wiped out and replaced with a single label: Underdeveloped. Suddenly, you weren't a proud community with a deep spiritual connection to your land; you were just a poor, backward country that needed to "catch up" to the United States and Europe. The western world appointed itself the pinnacle of human evolution. Everyone else was just standing in the waiting room of history.

This created a binary worldview. You were either "developed" or "underdeveloped". The prescription to fix ~~underdevelopment~~ underdevelopment was simple: Industrialize, privatize, extract resources, and copy the west.

Spider Alert: It didn't work out great for everyone. While this model created unprecedented wealth for a few, it also gave us climate change, massive wealth inequality, microplastics in our blood, and a global epidemic of anxiety and burnout. We essentially turned the planet into a giant ATM, and now the machine is flashing "Insufficient Funds".

De-essentialising: Breaking the Spell

De-essentialising development is essentially an intervention. It is humanity sitting itself down and saying, "look, we have a problem. This obsession with endless growth is destroying us".

When alternative models try to de-essentialize development, they are trying to strip away the assumptions we have taken for granted. They ask uncomfortable questions. Why is a country considered "developed" if it has high rates of depression, loneliness, and suicide just because its economy is huge? Why is a community considered "backward" if they sustainably, have strong social safety nets, and work fewer hours, just because they don't have a Starbucks on the corner?

primary goal of alternative models is to shift our understanding from singular path to a plurality of paths. They argue that development should not be a noun - Instead, it should be a verb - an ongoing process of improving well-being that looks completely different depending on your culture, your geography, and your values.

Let's look at how some of these alternative models achieve this goal in the real world.

Model 1: Buen Vivir (Living Well, Not Better)

If you want to see de-essentialization in action, look at Latin America. Indigenous communities in countries like Ecuador and Bolivia brought fourth a concept called Buen Vivir in Spanish, or Sumak Kawsay in Quechua language.

The Western model of development is based on the idea of "living better". And how do you live better? By making sure you have more than your neighbor. A bigger car, a bigger house, a bigger TV. It is inherently competitive and endless.

Buen Vivir, on the other hand, translates to "living well" or "good living". It throws the idea of individual accumulation right out the window. In this model, you cannot live well if the river you drink from is polluted with industrial waste.

Buen Vivir de-essentializes development by placing human beings inside the natural world, rather than above it. The traditional development model treats nature as a "resource" to be exploited - a warehouse of timber, oil, and minerals just waiting to be turned into profit. Buen Vivir views nature as a living entity with its own rights. In fact, Ecuador actually rewrote its constitution in 2008 to give nature legally enforceable rights.

Shocking, right? Giving a forest the right to not be bulldozed into a parking lot. It sounds radical to a Wall Street banker, but to the indigenous peoples of the Andes, it is just common sense. By adopting this model, they actively de-essentialize the idea that progress requires environmental destruction.

Model 2: Degrowth (Getting off the Treadmill)

While Buen Vivir comes from the Global South, the Global North has birthed its own religion against essentialized development: the degrowth movement.

The mainstream development model is obsessed with endless economic growth. It operates on the bizarre assumption that we can have infinite growth on a planet with finite resources. As the environmentalist Edward Abbey famously pointed out, "Growth for the sake of growth is the ideology of the cancer cell."

The Degrowth movement looks at the essentialized model of GDP growth and asks "Why are we running so fast, and where exactly are we going?"

Degrowth doesn't mean making everyone poor. It does not mean we all go back to living in caves and eating sour potatoes. Its goal is to de-essentialize development by shrinking the parts of the economy that are destructive and unnecessary while growing the things that actually matter.

The goal here is a planned, democratic reduction of production and consumption. It completely shatters the mainstream ~~It completely~~ illusion that a successful society must always produce more. Instead, Degrowth argues that once a society has met its basic needs, the goal should be to work less, share more, and enjoy life. ~~than more, and~~ It de-essentializes the idea that your worth as a human being is tied to your productivity and your purchasing power.

Model 3: Gross National Happiness (Bhutan)

Let's travel to the Himalayas. For decades, the tiny nation of Bhutan has been quietly mocking the global obsession with GDP by promoting its own alternate model: GNH.

When a country only measures GDP, it essentially tells its citizens that only money matters. If a forest is cut down and sold as timber, GDP goes up. If there is a massive oil ~~state~~ spill and millions are spent cleaning it up, GDP goes up. If people are so stressed they have to buy anti-depressants and pay for expensive therapy, GDP goes up. The traditional development metric literally rewards disasters and misery as long as money changes hands.

Bhutan's GNH de-essentializes development by changing the concept. GNH measures progress through four pillars: sustainable and equitable socio-economic development, environmental conservation, preservation and promotion of culture, and good governance. They actually ask their citizens how they are feeling. "How is your mental health?" "How is your community vitality? Do you feel culturally fulfilled?"

By doing this, Bhutan challenges the values of the global economic system. They prove that a country can choose to prioritize the psychological and ecological well-being of its people over the relentless pursuit of capital. They de-essentialize the very definition of a "successful nation."

Model 4: Eco-feminism and the Care Economy

We also cannot talk about alternative models without looking at Eco-feminism. The traditional, essentialized model of development is highly patriarchal. It values the "productive" economy — the things that can be bought and sold in a market, which has historically been the domain of men.

But it completely ignores the "reproductive" economy — the unpaid care work, cooking, cleaning, child-rearing, and community building that has historically fallen on women. If a mother cooks meals, raises three children to be decent human beings, and cares for her elderly parents, the traditional development model assigns her a value of zero dollars. She doesn't exist in the GDP calculations.

Alternative feminist models of development de-essentialize the idea that only "salaried work matters." They demand that we recognize the economy of care. After all, you cannot have a stock market, a tech company, or a factory if there isn't an invisible army of people doing the care work that keeps human beings alive, fed, and sane enough to go to work in the morning. Big centering care for people and the planet, rather than the domination of both, eco-feminism flips the mask off mainstream development and shows how incredibly narrow-minded it really is.

The Ultimate Goal: Creating a "Pluriverse"

So, when we look at all these alternative models – Buen Vivir, Degrowth, Gross National Happiness, Ubuntu or Ahimsa, Swaraj or Indie – what is their ultimate, unified goal? Their goal is to create what the Columbian anthropologist Arturo Escobar calls a "pluriverse." The essentialized model of development wants a universe. That meaning one. One way of thinking, one economic system, one idea of progress, one global culture of consumers buying the same products on Amazon.

The Alternative models want a pluriverse: "A world where many worlds fit," as the Zapatista movement in Mexico beautifully puts it.

The goal of de-essentialising development is not to replace the current system with a new, equally rigid system. The goal is to allow a thousand different flowers to bloom. It is the realization that a community in the Amazon rainforest will have a completely different definition of a "good life" than a community in rural France, or a neighborhood in Mumbai. And that is not just okay; that is necessary for human survival.

Diversity is the resilience of biology, and it is also the resilience of human society. If we all follow the exact same essentialized path, and that path leads over a cliff, we all fall off together. By de-essentialising development, we allow different cultures to find their own unique, sustainable paths forward.

Conclusion: Letting Go of the Magic Graph

In the end, de-essentialising development is about waking up from a collective trance. For ~~century~~ over seventy years, we have been hypnotized by the word "development," assuming it meant we were moving forward. We assumed that building more highways and producing more plastic waste was the inevitable peak of human civilization.

Alternative models are here to shake us by the shoulders and remind us that we have choices. We can choose to measure our success by the cleanliness of our rivers rather than the size of our factories. We can choose to look at a forest and see a sacred ecosystem rather than a pile of future furniture.

essentializing development is not an anti-progress stance. It is, frankly, the most progressive thing we can do. It is the evolution of human thought — moving past the childish idea that whoever dies with the most toys wins.

The real goal is to create a world where we don't need a magic GDP line to tell us we are doing okay. We will know we are doing okay because we will finally be able to breathe the air, drink the water, and maybe, just maybe, enjoy a decent night's sleep.